Ashoka as Buddhist convert, patron, and pilgrim is inseparable from Ashoka as spiritual regulator and protector of Buddhist unity. He styled himself a spiritual guide in a quite remarkable way on the hillside of Bairat, a Rajasthan town in a narrow valley surrounded by three concentric ranges of hills, some 85 km from Jaipur. The ancient settlement lies buried beneath the town. A couple of kilometres to the south-west of it, on top of a hill known as Bijak-ki-Pahari (‘inscription hill’), beneath a large boulder, a stone slab with a message for the Buddhist Sangha was installed by Ashoka, who identified himself as the ‘Magadha king’. This is today described as the Calcutta-Bairat edict because the stone bearing this record was taken away, after it was discovered in the middle of the nineteenth century, to the Asiatic Society of Bengal in Calcutta.



Fig. 10.11: The circular temple at Bairat. The Ashokan inscription was found below the overhanging rock at the edge of the hill